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THE INDIAN SCHOOL ADMISSION PLAYBOOK 2027-28

Nursery to Class I | Kendriya Vidyalaya | Navodaya | Sainik School

Four admission routes, one calendar, and the rules that decide each of them.
The RTE 25% free-seat quota, the Delhi points system, the KV lottery order,
the JNVST paper and the AISSEE application, decoded from government sources.

VERIFIED OCTOBER 2026

Every date, fee and rule traced to an official source - and every date re-verified before publication.

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How to use this playbook

Four admission systems decide where Indian children go to school, and they run on four different calendars. This book is built around that fact. Part 1 maps the four routes and the dates. Part 2 gets the paperwork out of the way. Parts 3 to 7 take one route each and explain how selection actually works, with the numbers. Part 8 turns all of it into a decision and a dated plan.

Read the part that matches your child's age, then read Part 8. You do not need to read it front to back, and there is nothing in here you are meant to memorise.

Three rules this book follows

- **Verified or absent.** Every date, fee and eligibility rule comes from a government document or portal, read on or before 28 October 2026. Where a fact could not be verified, it is not in the book.
- **Awaited means awaited.** Delhi's 2027-28 circular and the AISSEE 2027 bulletin had not been issued when this was written. The book says so, and shows you the previous cycle's dates as the pattern to plan against, rather than inventing a schedule.
- **Rules over rumours.** Every admission season produces fake notification screenshots. Each part ends by telling you which official page to check and what you should see on it.

> **What this book cannot do**
>
> It cannot get your child a seat. Four of the five selection mechanisms described here are draws or lotteries that nobody controls, and the fifth is a written test your child sits alone. What this book can do is make sure you are in every draw you qualify for, with the right documents, on the right date, with the right points claimed - which is where most families lose seats they were entitled to.

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PART 1

The Map

Four ways into a school, and which of them are open to your child this year.

1. Four doors, and most families only ever knock on one

There is no single school admission system in India. There are four, they run on different calendars, they select children by completely different rules, and one of them is free by law. Most parents learn about only the first, spend December to March anxious about it, and never claim the seat their child is legally entitled to.

Here are the four doors, in plain terms.

Door	Who runs it	How selection works	What it costs
Private school, open seats	The school, under state rules	A published points system, then a draw of lots among equal scores	Full fee
RTE 25% quota	The state education department	Income and category eligibility, then a computerised draw	Free to the end of Class 8
Kendriya Vidyalaya	Kendriya Vidyalaya Sangathan, Government of India	Priority categories, then lotteries in a fixed order	Very low fee
Navodaya or Sainik School	Navodaya Vidyalaya Samiti, Sainik Schools Society	A written entrance test, then merit and counselling	Navodaya free, Sainik subsidised

A child can apply to all four in the same year. Nothing in the rules stops you. The only real constraint is paperwork and the calendar, and both are manageable if you start in November rather than February.

The single most useful thing in this playbook

The RTE 25% quota is a statutory right, not a scholarship. Under Section 12(1)(c) of the Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education Act, 2009, every private unaided school must admit at least 25% of its Class I strength - and of its pre-school strength where it runs one - from children of weaker sections and disadvantaged groups in the neighbourhood, and educate them free to the end of elementary education. It is a lottery you are allowed to enter. In Delhi the income ceiling for the EWS route is a family income below Rs. 5 lakh a year.

2. The 2027-28 calendar you are actually working with

This is the whole admission year on one page, with the status of each item checked on 28 October 2026. Two entries are already fixed by official notification. Most of the rest will be announced between now and March, and the dates below are the pattern the previous cycle followed - not predictions dressed up as facts.

What	When	Status on 28 October 2026
JNVST 2027, Navodaya Class VI	28 November 2026	Fixed. Registration closed 10 August 2026
Delhi nursery, KG and Class I notification	Expected late November 2026	Not yet issued. The 2026-27 circular came on 22 November 2025

What	When	Status on 28 October 2026
Delhi private school forms open	Expected early December 2026	4 December in the 2026-27 cycle
Delhi forms close	Expected late December 2026	27 December in the 2026-27 cycle
AISSEE 2027, Sainik School Class VI and IX	31 January 2027	Exam date fixed in NTA's 16 September 2026 calendar. Notification not yet out
Delhi RTE and EWS applications	Expected February to March 2027	21 February to 23 March in the 2026-27 cycle
Kendriya Vidyalaya Class I and Balvatika registration	Expected mid-March to early April 2027	20 March to 2 April in the 2026-27 cycle
Navodaya result	End of March 2027	Stated in the JNVST 2027 prospectus
Sainik School e-counselling	March to May 2027	Follows the AISSEE result
Navodaya admission process closes	31 August 2027	Stated in the JNVST 2027 prospectus

Read that table again and notice what it means for you. If your child turns three before 31 March 2027, your real deadline is December 2026, not March. If your child is in Class V right now, the Navodaya test is in four weeks and the Sainik test is in three months. Everything in this book is timed against those two facts.

3. The 31 March rule decides which class your child enters

Every route in this book reckons age as on 31 March of the year of admission. Not the date of the form, not the date of the interview, not the child's birthday party. One date, one cut-off, and it is the same date across Kendriya Vidyalayas, Navodaya, Sainik Schools and Delhi's private schools.

The second thing to know is that India is mid-way through a structural change. The National Education Policy 2020 restructured the foundational stage into three years before Class I - Balvatika 1, 2 and 3, formerly nursery, lower KG and upper KG - with Class I starting at 6+ instead of 5+. Delhi's Directorate of Education has been phasing this in since 2026-27, and 2027-28 is the year the new structure actually bites.

Class	Age as on 31 March 2027	What changed
Nursery, Balvatika 1	3+ to under 4	Unchanged in substance
Lower KG, Balvatika 2	4+ to under 5	New class in Delhi from 2027-28
Upper KG, Balvatika 3	5+ to under 6	New class in Delhi from 2027-28
Class I	6+ to under 7	Rising from 5+ to 6+ in phases

Delhi allows the head of the school to relax the minimum or maximum age by up to one month, on a written request. That is a real concession and it is used every year, but it is discretionary - ask in writing, keep the reply, and do not assume it.

Outside Delhi the age bands are set by each state and they do not always match. Kendriya Vidyalaya is the clearest national reference point because its rules are published and uniform: Class I is for a child who is 6 but less than 8 on 31 March, Class II is 7 but less than 9, and the ladder continues to Class X at 14 but less than 16. Navodaya and Sainik do not use age bands at all - they publish a birth-date window, which is stricter and less forgiving.

Route	Age test	For 2027-28 entry
Delhi private schools	Band as on 31 March 2027	Nursery 3+, LKG 4+, UKG 5+, Class I 6+
Kendriya Vidyalaya	6 but under 8 as on 31 March 2027	Born between 1 April 2019 and 31 March 2021

Route	Age test	For 2027-28 entry
Navodaya JNVST 2027	Born 1 May 2015 to 31 July 2017	Currently in Class V in 2026-27
Sainik School AISSEE 2027	10 to 12 as on 31 March 2027	Per the 2026 cycle. The 2027 bulletin is not out yet

A word of caution on the last two rows. The Navodaya window is quoted from the JNVST 2027 prospectus and is final. The Sainik row reflects the 2026 bulletin's rule; the 2027 bulletin is not out yet, and the age window is one of the things that can move by a few weeks. Confirm it against the bulletin the day it appears.

4. What the law already guarantees you

Parents negotiate from a weak position because they assume the school holds all the cards. It does not. Four sections of the RTE Act, 2009 apply to every recognised private school in the country, and knowing them changes the conversation at the admission desk.

- No capitation fee, no screening. Section 13(1) prohibits a school from collecting any capitation fee, or subjecting a child or parent to any screening procedure, while admitting a child. A capitation fee is defined in Section 2(b) as any donation, contribution or payment other than the fee notified by the school. Screening is defined in Section 2(o) as any selection method other than a random one.
- The penalty is real. Section 13(2) sets the fine at up to ten times the capitation fee charged, and Rs. 25,000 for a first screening violation, rising to Rs. 50,000 for each subsequent one.
- No child can be refused for want of age proof. Section 14(2) is blunt about it, and Section 15 says a child shall not be denied admission if the request comes after the extended period either.
- No child can be held back or expelled until elementary education is complete, under Section 16, and Section 17 prohibits physical punishment and mental harassment.

Two practical consequences. First, an interaction or observation session where a three-year-old is watched, scored and ranked is a screening procedure, and it is unlawful in a recognised private school. Second, a school that asks for a development fee or a donation as the condition for confirming a seat is charging a capitation fee. You do not have to argue this at the counter. You write it down, you keep the receipt, and you take it to the district education officer.

Where to take a complaint

Delhi runs a district-level Monitoring Cell under each Deputy Director of Education, with a grievance link on edudel.nic.in. Kendriya Vidyalaya grievances go to the Principal in writing first, then to the Deputy Commissioner of the region. Navodaya and Sainik both publish grievance channels on their own portals. The one thing that works in all four is a dated written complaint with a copy retained, not a phone call.

PART 2

The Document Vault

Assemble twelve papers in November and you will never miss a deadline because of paperwork.

5. Twelve documents, and where each one actually comes from

Document failure, not merit, is the most common reason an application dies. The fix is unglamorous: build the file once, in November, and stop thinking about it. Here is the complete list, ordered by how long each one takes to obtain, so start at the top.

Document	Where it comes from	Lead time	Notes
Birth certificate	Municipal corporation, notified area council, panchayat or military hospital records	1 day to 3 weeks	Must come from a competent authority, not a hospital letter
Aadhaar, child and both parents	Aadhaar enrolment or update centre	Same day to 2 weeks	Name must match the birth certificate exactly
Residence proof	Ration or smart card, domicile certificate, voter ID, electricity, water or telephone bill, passport, Aadhaar	Already have it	Any one is enough in Delhi. Keep two
Income certificate, EWS only	Revenue department, tehsil or SDM office	1 to 3 weeks	Must be dated before the RTE window closes
Caste certificate, SC, ST or OBC-NCL	Tehsil, SDM or the state e-district portal	1 to 4 weeks	OBC-NCL also needs the non-creamy-layer certificate
Domicile certificate	Tehsil or SDM office	1 to 3 weeks	Required for Sainik School and for the Navodaya district rule
Disability certificate or UDID	Government hospital or the UDID portal	2 to 6 weeks	Benchmark disability of 40% or more
Service certificate with transfer count	Your own office, signed by the head of office	2 to 5 days	Kendriya Vidyalaya only. Must show transfers in the last 7 years
Transfer certificate from the last school	The previous school	1 day to 1 week	Needed for Class II and above, not for Class I
Passport photographs	Any studio	1 day	Six copies, child alone, plain background
Left thumb impression	A stamp pad and a phone camera	1 day	Sainik School application. Right thumb if the left is unavailable
Bank account in the child's name	Any bank, with the school's bonafide certificate	1 week	Useful later for scholarship and DBT payments

Two items on that list are routinely overlooked and both are cheap to fix now: the domicile certificate and the income certificate. A family that decides in February to try the RTE route usually discovers it cannot get an income certificate issued and dated before the window closes. Get it in December. It costs a form and a visit.

6. APAAR and PEN: the two IDs schools now ask for

Alongside Aadhaar, two education-specific identifiers have become routine in admission files. Parents meet them for the first time on an application form and assume they are optional. In practice they are not.

PEN is the student's Permanent Education Number in UDISE+, the national school database. Every child enrolled in a recognised school gets one, and it follows the child between schools. APAAR - Automated Permanent Academic Account Registry, the One Nation One Student ID - is a 12-digit lifelong academic ID built on top of it, launched on 13 February 2024 and aligned with the National Education Policy 2020.

The creation route is school-mediated, not something you do alone:

- The school verifies the child's demographic details against Aadhaar.
- A parent signs a consent form. Consent is voluntary and physical, and the parent's signature is what starts the process.
- UDISE+ generates the APAAR ID against the child's PEN.
- The ID is pushed into the child's DigiLocker account, where it appears as an issued document.

Two prerequisites trip families up. The name in UDISE+ must match the name in Aadhaar, and PEN is mandatory before an APAAR can be generated at all. If the child is new to the school system, or has moved schools, ask the class teacher for the PEN first and fix name mismatches before applying anywhere else. The APAAR helpline is 1800-889-3511, and the status of any child's ID can be checked by the school in the UDISE+ APAAR module.

Why this matters at admission

When you change schools - and most children in this book will change schools at least once - the receiving school asks for the transfer certificate, the PEN and increasingly the APAAR ID. A child whose records are clean in UDISE+ moves in a day. A child whose name reads differently across three documents can lose a week to verification, and in a mid-year vacancy a week is the whole vacancy.

7. Four document problems that quietly kill applications

These four account for most of the rejections described in official circulars and court records. Each has a fix, and none of the fixes requires an agent.

The name does not match. The birth certificate says Aarav Kumar Singh, Aadhaar says Aarav K Singh, and the previous school's register says Aarav Singh. In a verification queue this is a flag. Fix it by getting Aadhaar updated to match the birth certificate, because the birth certificate is the document the law treats as authoritative for age and identity. Do this before you apply, not after you are selected.

The address does not match the school's neighbourhood map. Delhi's rules are explicit: the address entered and the address proof submitted during the application are final for determining the neighbourhood, and no change of address is entertained afterwards except for government employees shifting to government accommodation. Fix it by deciding which address you will use before you fill the form, and making sure the proof you upload is in a parent's or the child's name for that address.

The birth certificate does not exist. It happens, especially for children born at home or in a facility that has since closed. The municipal registrar can register a delayed birth after verification, and a school may accept other proof under state rules. Kendriya Vidyalaya accepts extracts from municipal records, notified area councils, panchayat records and military hospital records. Do not fabricate one. Section 14(2) protects you from being refused for lacking proof, not from being refused for producing a forged one.

A certificate has expired. Income and domicile certificates carry validity periods in most states, and an income certificate issued in 2025 may be worthless in a 2027 application. Check the issue date against the application deadline, and get a fresh one in the month the window opens.

PART 3

Delhi Private Schools

The points system is published, the dates are fixed, and the maths is knowable before you apply.

8. The points system is not a mystery, it is published

Delhi is the one large school system in India where private entry-level admission is genuinely rule-bound. Every recognised private unaided school must publish its admission criteria and the points attached to each criterion on the Directorate of Education's portal before the process opens, and the DoE publishes the whole district-wise list for public viewing. You can read every school's formula before you choose which six to apply to.

Here is what the published 2026-27 criteria actually look like, taken from the DoE's own district-wise report. These are real schools and real numbers.

School	Neighbourhood	Sibling	Alumni	Other
Sanskriti School, Chanakyapuri	30 within 10 km, 20 to 12 km, 10 to 14 km, 0 beyond	25	25 for parent alumni	Total 110
Tagore Modern Public School, Motia Khan	70 within 1 km, 60 to 3 km, 40 to 6 km, 20 beyond	20	5	Girl child 5
Bal Bharati, Ganga Ram Hospital Marg	50, then 0 to 8 km 50, beyond 8 km 30	20	10	First-born 20, management 20%, staff 5%
N. K. Bagrodia, Dwarka	70 within 2 km, 60 to 4 km, 50 to 6 km, 40 beyond	30 for sibling, staff or alumni	-	EWS 25%, open 55%, management 20% of 240
Guru Harkrishan, Karol Bagh	20 within 1 km, 15 to 3 km, 8 to 6 km, 3 beyond	10	10	Sikh minority 35, single parent 5, girl child 10
Springdales, Pusa Road	39 for listed areas, 29 for others	35	26 above 11 years, 16 for 5 to 10, 11 under 5	Total 156

Three things jump out of that table, and all three are actionable.

- Distance dominates, and the bands vary wildly. One school gives 70 points inside a kilometre. Another gives 30 inside ten kilometres. Your points total for the same flat can differ by 40 across two schools on the same road. This is why you compute before you apply.
- Minority schools award a large block of points for community. A Sikh minority school can award 35 points for being Sikh, which dwarfs the 3 points it gives for living beyond six kilometres. If you belong to the school's minority community, that is the single biggest lever available to you.
- Seats are split before the points system even starts. In a 240-seat nursery, 25% is reserved for EWS, DG and CWSN, 20% is management quota, and the points system decides only the remaining 55% - 132 seats. The number you are competing for is smaller than the number on the brochure.

Two limits keep this fair-ish. The DoE has abolished 62 criteria found unfair, unreasonable or non-transparent, and the Delhi High Court upheld the abolition in WP(C) 448/2016, so a school cannot revive them. And every school must display the break-up of points for every criterion on its own website as well as the DoE portal. If the two do not match, that is a grievance.

9. What the 2026-27 cycle looked like, day by day

The 2027-28 circular has not been issued yet. Rather than guess, work from the last full cycle, which is documented in the DoE circular dated 22 November 2025 and covered in detail by the press at the time. Every date below is a real 2026-27 date; the pattern is what you plan against.

Stage	2026-27 date	What you do
Schools upload criteria and points	28 November 2025	Read your shortlist's criteria the day they appear
Forms open	4 December 2025	Apply in the first week, not the last
Forms close	27 December 2025	Never assume an extension
Schools upload applicant details	9 January 2026	Check that you appear
Schools upload points per applicant	16 January 2026	Recompute your own score and compare
First list and waiting list published	23 January 2026	Accept or wait, in writing
Query window on the first list	24 January to 3 February 2026	Your only real appeal window
Second list published	9 February 2026	Movement happens here
Query window on the second list	10 to 16 February 2026	Short, so be ready
Subsequent list, if any	5 March 2026	Where late vacancies surface
Process closes	19 March 2026	After this, only mid-year vacancies remain

The circular also fixes several things that protect you and that schools sometimes forget. The registration fee is capped at Rs. 25, non-refundable, and nothing else may be charged at the application stage. Buying the prospectus must be optional. Forms must remain available until the last date of submission. The number of entry-level seats cannot fall below the highest number offered in the previous three years. The schedule may not be varied, and must be displayed on the school's notice board and website. Where applications exceed seats, the draw of lots must be held in front of parents, with the slips shown openly, at least two days' notice given, and the whole thing video-recorded and retained by the school.

10. Pick your six schools with the points in your hand

Applying to one school is the most common strategic mistake in Delhi. Applying to twelve is the second most common, because it costs you the attention needed to do each one properly. Six is the working number: two where you are near-certain to be competitive, two where you have a real chance, and two where you are applying on hope.

Work through this in one sitting, with a map open.

- Measure the actual road distance from home to each candidate school, not the straight-line distance. Several schools explicitly use the shortest road distance on Google Maps, and Sanskriti's published criterion says so.
- For each school, write down the points you would score under its published criteria: neighbourhood band, sibling, alumni, girl child, first-born, staff ward, minority community, single parent, special needs.
- Sort the schools by your score, then by the number of open seats. A 70-point score in a school with 132 open seats is a different proposition from 70 points in a school with 24.

- Cut any school where your score is more than 20 points below last year's last-admitted score. That cut-off is not published as such, but last year's first list, with points shown against each name, usually is - on the school's website or in a parents' group. That document is the closest thing to a cut-off that exists.
- Now check the age band and the fee. A school where your child falls outside the band is not a candidate, however good the points.
- Apply to all six in the first week of December, and keep the acknowledgement for each.

One honest caveat: the points system decides who enters the draw, not who is admitted. When more applicants tie on the top score than there are seats left, the school draws lots among them. A parent with 70 points in a school where 200 others also have 70 points has a 70-point application and no advantage at all. That is why the second and third lists move as much as they do.

11. Filling the form: the fields, and the seven mistakes

The application is short. Almost every field is a place to lose points rather than gain them.

- The address. This one is final. It decides your neighbourhood band, which is usually the largest single block of points. Use the address where you actually live and where you can produce a document in a parent's or the child's name.
- The sibling claim. Delhi schools award sibling points for a real brother or sister currently studying in the same school. In a 2026 judgment the Delhi High Court upheld a school's refusal to award sibling points to a half-sibling who had already passed out, because the criteria said real sibling and existing student and both conditions had to be met. Read the school's exact wording before you claim it.
- The alumni claim. Most schools require specific proof: an alumni registration number, a Class X or XII pass certificate from that school, or a minimum number of years studied. Keep the document ready before you fill the field.
- The first-born and girl-child claims. These are usually self-declared but verified at admission. Do not claim both if the school's criteria treat them as alternatives.
- The category field. The open-seat process is not the EWS process. If you are eligible for the RTE quota, apply there too - it is a separate application on a separate portal, and applying to open seats does not disqualify you.
- The contact number. One working mobile number that you check daily, and an email you actually open. Every list, query window and admission notice comes through them.
- The documents upload. Upload what the circular lists, in the format asked for, at a readable resolution. A blurry electricity bill is the same as no electricity bill.

Then the seventh mistake, which is not a field at all: not checking. Between 9 and 16 January the school uploads your details and your points. Open the school's page on both dates. If your points are wrong, the query window that follows is the mechanism to fix it, and it is ten days long. Parents who discover an error in March have no remedy left.

12. First list, waiting list, and the appeal that actually works

When the first list appears it will show three things: the children selected, the waiting list, and the points each child scored. Read your own points line before you read anything else. If they are wrong, you have from the day after the list until the query window closes to raise it in writing - email and letter, with the school's criteria page attached and your own calculation shown.

If your points are right and you are on the waiting list, do three things and nothing more. Confirm in writing that you wish to remain on the waiting list. Ask, in the same letter, for your position on it. Then wait, because

the second list on the pattern of 9 February is where movement happens: families hold multiple offers, and seats released by non-joining children flow down.

If you believe the school has applied its own published criteria unfairly, the escalation ladder is short and it is documented. First, the school in writing, inside the query window. Second, the district Monitoring Cell under the Deputy Director of Education, which the DoE constituted in every district specifically to ensure schools upload criteria, do not use abolished criteria, and publish applicant and admitted lists with points. Third, the grievance link on edudel.nic.in under Grievance Redressal and Monitoring System. What does not work is a phone call, a visit to the principal's office without a written record, or a complaint filed after the process closes on the pattern of 19 March.

The waiting-list letter that gets a reply

Keep it to five lines: your child's name, registration number, the list and points concerned, the specific factual error or the specific request such as position on the waiting list, and a request for a written response by a named date. Attach the school's own criteria page. Send it by email and keep the sent copy. Schools answer documented queries because the district cell can ask them to.

PART 4

The RTE 25% Quota

The free seat is a legal entitlement. Most eligible families never apply for it.

13. The free seat most families never claim

Section 12(1)(c) of the RTE Act requires every private unaided school, and every aided school to a minimum of 25%, to admit in Class I at least 25% of the class strength from children belonging to weaker sections and disadvantaged groups in the neighbourhood, and to provide them free and compulsory elementary education until it is complete. Where the school imparts pre-school education, the same obligation applies to that pre-school.

Read the second half of that paragraph again, because it is where the money is. A child admitted to nursery under this quota in a school that runs nursery is entitled to free education not just through Class 8, but from nursery onwards. In a school charging Rs. 8,000 a month, that is roughly Rs. 11 lakh of schooling the family never pays.

Three structural facts decide whether this is available to you.

- Minority schools are exempt. A school established and administered by a religious or linguistic minority sits outside this obligation, because Article 30 of the Constitution protects its right to run its own institutions. A large share of Delhi's best-known schools fall in this category, and no amount of paperwork will change that.
- The income test is set by the state, not by Delhi's number. Delhi's EWS ceiling is a total family income below Rs. 5 lakh a year. Other states use very different figures, some as low as Rs. 1 lakh. Your state's number is the one that applies.
- Selection is a lottery, not a merit test. Where applications exceed seats, allotment is by computerised draw. There is nothing to prepare for and nothing to negotiate. The work is entirely in the application and the documents.

14. Delhi's EWS, DG and CWSN route, step by step

Delhi runs the 25% quota centrally, on its own portal, and schools are explicitly barred from processing these admissions themselves. That is good news: the draw is not in the principal's office.

Item	The rule
Split of the 25%	22% for EWS and DG together, 3% for children with special needs
Entry classes	Nursery, KG and Class I
EWS eligibility	Delhi resident, total annual family income below Rs. 5 lakh
DG eligibility	SC, ST, OBC non-creamy layer, orphans, transgender children, children living with or affected by HIV
CWSN eligibility	Benchmark disability of 40% or more, certified
Application	One application per child, one mobile number. Multiple applications cancel the candidature
Portal	ewsadmissions.delhi.gov.in
Selection	Computerised draw, allotted largely by residential address

Item	The rule
Verification	DoE zonal teams, with families told their centre by SMS
Appeal	District Admission Monitoring Committee, with a reasoned order in writing

The 2026-27 cycle ran like this, and it is the pattern to plan against. Applications opened on 21 February 2026 and closed on 23 March 2026, after an extension from 16 March. The first draw was on 6 April, with the last date to report to the allotted school on 20 May. A second draw followed on 10 July and a final draw on 24 September, with reporting by 31 October 2026.

Two details from that cycle matter more than the dates. First, seats left empty by rejected or non-reporting candidates go back into the next draw, which is why the July and September draws are worth waiting for and why a family that gives up after the first draw may be giving up a seat that arrives in July. Second, the DoE's 2026-27 circulars noted that the allotment was subject to the outcome of a case pending in the Delhi High Court, so watch for orders before relying on any single draw.

Once a child is recommended, the school's job is administrative and it is checked. The school admits the child when the family reports with the zonal order, marks the status on the portal, charges no tuition fee and no capitation of any kind, provides free books within a week of reporting, and holds one introduction session for all new parents together. The allotted school cannot be changed. If the school refuses, the zonal order is the document you take to the district cell.

There is a second, less-known door. Private schools sitting on government-allotted land carry a wider obligation: they must also admit EWS children up to 20% of fresh admissions in classes above the entry level, filled through the DoE's separate EWS and Freeship draw for Class 2 onwards, and they must continue free education beyond the elementary stage under the Delhi RTE Rules. In 2026-27 that separate window ran in September, after the entry-level draws had closed. If your child is already in Class 2 or above and you missed the entry-level window, this is the door still open.

15. Outside Delhi: find your portal, check three things

Every state implements Section 12(1)(c), but each has its own portal, its own income limit and its own distance rules. Rather than list twenty state websites that change, here is the method, which works everywhere.

- Search your state education department's site, not a coaching or news site. The portal usually carries the name RTE 25% admissions and sits on a state government domain. Delhi's is ewsadmissions.delhi.gov.in. Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Gujarat each run their own. Start from the department's home page and follow the link.
- Check the income limit. This is the single number that decides eligibility and it varies from about Rs. 1 lakh to Rs. 5 lakh across states. It is set by notification, so it can change between cycles.
- Check the distance rule. Most states give priority by neighbourhood radius, commonly within 1 km, then 3 km, then 5 km, with siblings preferred inside each band. A few use block-level allocation instead.
- Check whether pre-school is covered. Where a school runs pre-school, the quota applies to it. This is the difference between a free seat in Class I and a free seat in nursery, and it is worth checking on the portal rather than assuming.

If the portal is confusing, use the help desk. Every state is required to run one free of charge, and the Common Service Centre network is meant to offer RTE application assistance in rural areas at no cost. Andhra Pradesh's published standard operating procedure, for instance, puts application support at every village and ward secretariat. If a private agent offers to file your RTE form for a fee, you are paying for something the state provides free.

16. Nine reasons RTE applications get rejected

Rejection is usually procedural, and every item on this list is avoidable.

- An income certificate issued by the wrong authority, or issued after the application deadline. It must predate the close of the window.
- An income certificate for one parent rather than the household. The test is total family income from all sources.
- An OBC claim on a state list where the rules require the central list. Navodaya and Sainik both specify the central list, and several state RTE portals do the same.
- Two applications for one child. Delhi cancels the candidature even if the child was selected in the draw.
- Two applications on the same mobile number. One number, one registration.
- A residence proof in someone else's name - a landlord, a relative, an employer - with no document connecting the family to the address.
- A disability claim without a valid certificate from a designated authority, or below the 40% benchmark.
- Not reporting to the allotted school by the stated last date. The seat returns to the pool and your candidature ends.
- Not keeping the income self-declaration current. Delhi's rules require an annual self-declaration on affidavit to keep a free seat. A child cannot be removed for missing it without the Director's prior approval, but the declaration still has to be filed.

Apply to both routes in the same year

Applying for the RTE quota does not bar you from the school's open-seat process, and applying to open seats does not bar you from the quota. They are separate applications on separate portals with separate draws. A family eligible for EWS should do both, because the outcomes are independent, and the quota result usually arrives before the open-seat lists.

PART 5

Kendriya Vidyalaya

The cheapest good school in the country, run on published rules and open to everyone.

17. Who actually gets into a KV

The most persistent myth about Kendriya Vidyalayas is that they are only for central government employees. KVS contradicts this in its own admission guidelines: the advertisement for Class I registration must state specifically that admissions are not restricted to central government employees and are open to all, and that only certain priorities have been laid down to regulate admissions. Priority is not eligibility.

What the priorities do is decide who fills the seats first. For a KV under the civil or defence sector, the order is:

- Children of transferable and non-transferable central government employees, and children of ex-servicemen.
- Children of transferable and non-transferable employees of autonomous bodies, public sector undertakings and institutes of higher learning of the Government of India.
- Children of transferable and non-transferable state government employees.
- Children of transferable and non-transferable employees of autonomous bodies, PSUs and institutes of higher learning of the state governments.
- Everyone else - all children not covered above.

Within each category, preference goes by the number of transfers the parent has had in the last seven years. Transfer has a precise definition in the guidelines: a move by a competent authority from one place or urban agglomeration to another at least 20 km away, with a minimum stay of six months or 180 days at a place, counting the day of relieving. That definition is why the service certificate matters, and why a certificate that merely says transferable post is not enough.

A KV under the project or institute-of-higher-learning sector has a different ladder, because the sponsoring organisation comes first: children of the sponsoring project or institute's employees, faculty and postgraduate students on long-term research projects, and regular Council of Wardens employees, then children of retired employees including those on deputation and directly hired contractual staff. Staff hired through an agency, outsourced or third-party are explicitly given no priority.

If you are in the last category, you are not out of the running. You are last in line for the seats that survive the first four, and in a popular KV that usually means none. Apply anyway: the vacancy rules mean seats do open, and a registration costs you an hour.

18. Forty seats, eleven lotteries: the order decoded

A Class I section in a KV is 40 children. The guidelines allocate those 40 seats before a single name is drawn, and the arithmetic is published.

Quota	Seats out of 40	Basis
RTE 25%	10	Draw from SC, ST, EWS, BPL and OBC-NCL applicants living in the neighbourhood, taken together
SC 15%	6	Reserved

Quota	Seats out of 40	Basis
ST 7.5%	3	Reserved
OBC-NCL 27%	11	Reserved
CwSN 3%	Horizontal	Reserved across all categories, not a separate block

The RTE seats may include the SC, ST and OBC-NCL seats, which is why the numbers do not simply add to 40. The shortfall in the reserved categories is calculated after counting reserved-category children already admitted under RTE, Category 1 and Category 2.

Then the lotteries run in a fixed sequence, and the sequence is the whole game: RTE, then CwSN, then Category 1, then Category 2, then SC, then ST, then OBC, then Category 3, then Category 4, then Category 5, then Category 6 where applicable.

Two consequences follow. Being in Category 1 or 2 gets you a lottery before any reserved-category lottery runs, which is why the transfer certificate matters so much. And the SC, ST and OBC lotteries run after Categories 1 and 2, not before, so a reserved-category child from a Category 1 family is admitted under Category 1 and the reserved seat stays available for someone else. That is what the shortfall being worked out afterwards means in practice.

One rule here is unusually strict and worth reading twice: unfilled leftover reserved seats are kept vacant. RTE seats are never de-reserved. A KV with an unfilled RTE quota advertises separately for offline registration from that category rather than converting the seat.

19. The Class I window and the documents that decide it

For 2026-27, online registration for Class I and Balvatika opened at 10 am on 20 March 2026 and closed on 2 April 2026, on admission.kvs.gov.in. Registration for Balvatika 2 and 3 where online admission does not run, and for Class II and above, followed offline from 2 to 8 April 2026, and only if vacancies existed. Expect the same shape in 2027, in the second half of March.

The document list for Class I is short, but each item has a specific acceptable form, and specific is the operative word.

- Proof of age: a birth certificate issued by the authority competent to register births. That includes a notified area council, municipality or municipal corporation, an extract from village panchayat records, a military hospital record, or service records of defence personnel. The original is returned after verification.
- Category certificate: SC, ST, EWS, OBC non-creamy layer or BPL, issued by the competent authority of the concerned state or union government. The certificate in either parent's name may be accepted initially; the child's own certificate must be submitted within three months of admission.
- CwSN certificate from a civil surgeon, rehabilitation centre or other competent authority, where applicable. Where the disability is visible to the Principal, the child may be accepted without one, with a certificate advised later.
- Service certificate showing the number of transfers in the preceding seven years, signed and stamped by the head of office, with name and designation in block letters. This is the document that establishes your category.
- Retirement certificate, for uniformed defence employees.
- Proof of residence.

Three rules in the guidelines are worth memorising because they are enforced. Mere registration confers no right to admission. Incomplete application forms are normally rejected, with completion allowed later only at the Principal's discretion if vacancies remain. And admission secured on a wrong certificate or wrong

address is cancelled forthwith, with no appeal, which is why the address you enter must be the address you can prove and why it is treated as final for neighbourhood purposes once submitted.

One further detail for double-shift KVs: each shift is treated as a separate Vidyalaya for admission, no change of shift is permitted, and if multiple registration forms are submitted for the same child in the same KV, only the last one is considered.

20. Balvatika: the pre-primary door at selected KVs

Kendriya Vidyalayas now run Balvatika classes, the NEP 2020 three-year pre-primary stage, at selected schools. For 2026-27 the ages as on 31 March 2026 were 3 to 4 for Balvatika 1, 4 to 5 for Balvatika 2 and 5 to 6 for Balvatika 3, and registration for Balvatika 1 ran online in the same window as Class I.

This matters for two reasons. It is a genuinely low-cost pre-primary option in a system most parents assume starts at Class I. And a child inside a KV's Balvatika is inside the system before the Class I lotteries run. Check the KVS list of Balvatika schools on kvsangathan.nic.in before you plan around it, because the facility exists only where it has been sanctioned.

21. Class II and above: the offline vacancy route

Almost everyone applies for Class I and then stops. The vacancy route is where families who missed the entry-level window, or who move cities mid-year, actually get in.

The pattern from 2026-27: registration for Class II and above, and for Balvatika 2 and 3 where online admission does not run, opened offline from 2 April to 8 April 2026, only if vacancies existed, with the form submitted to the Principal's office at the KV concerned. Information appeared on individual Vidyalaya websites, not centrally. Where a vacancy arises later in the year, the guidelines allow registration after wide publicity at local level, on the Vidyalaya website and notice board.

The practical routine, therefore, is a short loop rather than a single application: identify three or four KVs within reach, check their individual websites in the first week of April and again in the first week of July, and keep a filled form and the document set ready to submit the same day a vacancy appears. Class II admission also does not require a transfer certificate, because the guidelines allow admission up to Class VIII without one, provided the child is otherwise eligible and the birth certificate was issued by a government body.

> **The fee reality**
> Kendriya Vidyalaya fees are set centrally and are a small fraction of private school fees, which is the whole reason the last-category queue exists. Do not treat a KV as a fallback. Treat it as the default application for any child who is eligible, and let the lottery decide.

PART 6

Navodaya

Free residential schooling for a child who can pass one test in November.

22. What a JNV actually gives your child

There are 665 functional Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalayas across 27 states and 8 union territories, run by Navodaya Vidyalaya Samiti, an autonomous body under the Ministry of Education. The design is unusual and deliberately so: one JNV per district, co-educational and residential, with separate hostels for boys and girls, admitting children at Class VI and carrying them to Class XII under the CBSE.

The money is the headline. Education is free, including board and lodging, uniform and textbooks. A Vidyalaya Vikas Nidhi of Rs. 600 a month is collected only from students of Classes IX to XII, and SC and ST students, Divyang students, all girl students, and students from below-poverty-line families are exempt. For wards of government employees outside the exempted categories, the charge is Rs. 1,500 a month or the actual Children Education Allowance received, whichever is less, subject to a floor of Rs. 600.

The less obvious benefit is the one that changes outcomes. The medium of instruction is the mother tongue or regional language up to Class VIII, then English for Mathematics and Science and Hindi for Social Science. Students sit CBSE board examinations. There is a migration scheme under which a share of students spend time in a JNV in a different linguistic region, which is how a child from a Hindi-speaking district ends up fluent in a second language. And there is structured sport, NCC, Scouts and Guides, and NSS.

What a JNV is not

It is not a school you can join by moving house, and it is not a school you can apply to outside your own district. Selection is by the Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya Selection Test, and the district you apply in is fixed by where the child studies Class V. This is the single rule that surprises families most, and it is covered in Section 24.

23. JNVST 2027: the paper, section by section

The test is on 28 November 2026, from 11:30 am to 1:30 pm, in a single phase for both summer-bound and winter-bound JNVs. It is a pen-and-paper OMR test with one booklet containing all three sections. Here is the exact composition, from the JNVST 2027 prospectus.

Section	Questions	Marks	Time	Content
Mental Ability and EVS	20 plus 20	50	60 minutes	Non-verbal reasoning, then EVS
Arithmetic	20	25	30 minutes	Class V syllabus, 12 topics
Language	20	25	30 minutes	Four passages, five questions each
Total	80	100	2 hours	No negative marking

The scoring is where strategy lives. Each correct answer earns 1.25 marks, and there is no negative marking, so there is never a reason to leave a bubble empty. But qualifying is sectional: a candidate must score at least 14 marks in Mental Ability and EVS, 7 in Arithmetic and 7 in Language. A child who scores 70 overall but 6 in Arithmetic does not qualify. That single rule should shape the last four weeks of preparation more than any other.

The Mental Ability section is entirely non-verbal - questions based on figures and diagrams, in five parts: pattern completion including alphabetical and number patterns, figure series completion, geometrical figure completion with triangles, squares and circles, mirror and water images, and embedded figures. Twenty of the forty questions in that first section are Environmental Studies, of which fifteen are multiple choice and five follow a single passage. The EVS syllabus is the Class III to V EVS course: the natural world, the human body, science in daily life, and social surroundings including states and capitals, national symbols, festivals, seasons, forests and crops.

Arithmetic is twenty questions from twelve named topics: number and numeric system, the four fundamental operations on whole numbers, factors and multiples, fractions with addition and subtraction of like fractions and multiplication, measurement of length, mass, capacity, time and money with unit conversion, simplification of numerical expressions, perimeter and area of polygons and of squares, rectangles and triangles, types of angles with simple applications including directions and mapping, and data analysis using bar diagrams, tables and pictographs. Note what is excluded: division of fractional numbers is not in the syllabus. Do not spend November on it.

Language is reading comprehension, full stop. Four passages, five questions each, all objective.

24. Eligibility, and the district rule that catches families out

Four conditions, all of them mandatory, from the JNVST 2027 prospectus.

- The child must be a bonafide resident of the district where admission is sought.
- The child must be studying in Class V during the 2026-27 session in a recognised school.
- The child must have been born between 1 May 2015 and 31 July 2017, both dates inclusive.
- The child must have spent the full academic session in Class III, IV and V.

Then the rule that voids applications: selection is district-specific, and a candidate can apply only for the district where the child was residing and studying Class V. Submitting fraudulent information about residence or study details is grounds for immediate cancellation at any stage, without notice. Because all applicant data is captured and processed electronically, the submitted data is treated as final and binding. There is a correction window - in the 2027 cycle it ran on 11 and 12 August 2026 - and after that there is no administrative provision for post-submission correction of demographic or academic particulars.

For the 2027 cycle, registration opened on 6 July 2026, was free of cost, and closed on 10 August 2026 after an extension from 31 July. That window has closed, which matters for how you read this book.

> **If your child is in Class V now and not registered**
>
> The 2027 test is closed to you. Two things remain. If your child is also eligible for AISSEE 2027 on 31 January 2027, that route is still open, and Part 7 covers it. Otherwise, plan for JNVST 2028, whose registration will open around July 2027, and use the twelve months to build the reading habit and the arithmetic fluency the test actually rewards. Register in the first week the portal opens, not the last.

25. Reservation, the rural quota, and the tie-break ladder

Seventy-five per cent of the seats in a district are filled from candidates provisionally selected from rural areas. There is no reservation for urban candidates: after the rural candidates are selected under the reservation norms, the remaining seats are open and filled on merit from both rural and urban candidates of the district.

The rural test is strict. A candidate seeking admission under the rural quota must have studied Classes III, IV and V, spending the full academic session, in government, government-aided or government-recognised schools located in rural areas, and must have studied Class V for a full session in the same district where admission is sought. A child who studied in a school located in an urban area even for a single day of the session in Classes III, IV or V is treated as an urban candidate. Rural and urban are defined by government notification as on the last date for submission of the application.

On top of that sit the reservation blocks.

Category	Rule
SC and ST	In proportion to population in the district, but never less than the national average of 15% for SC and 7.5% for ST, and capped at 50% for the two together. Interchangeable if qualified candidates are unavailable
OBC	27% as per the central list, over and above SC and ST. A candidate not on the central list applies as general
Girls	At least one third of the total seats
Divyang	As per Government of India norms, with benchmark disability of 40% or more
Transgender	No separate reservation. Included in the boys category for rural, urban, OBC, SC, ST and Divyang sub-categories

Ties are broken in a published order, and it is worth knowing because it decides real seats. Higher marks in Mental Ability and EVS first. If those are equal, higher marks in Arithmetic. Then an ST candidate over an SC candidate, an SC candidate over general and OBC, an OBC candidate over general, a girl over a boy, and finally the younger candidate, on the reasoning that a younger child scoring the same marks has the better IQ level.

26. The last four weeks: a plan to 28 November

If your child is registered for JNVST 2027, the test is 31 days away as this is written. Four weeks is enough to move a borderline candidate into qualifying range, provided the work is aimed at the right thing. It is not enough to build new competence in arithmetic from scratch, so do not try.

The plan assumes 95 minutes a day, six days a week, with Sunday off. Split it as 40 minutes of mental ability and EVS, 30 minutes of arithmetic, and 25 minutes of reading a passage and answering questions on it.

Week	Focus	Weekly target
Week 1, 28 Oct to 3 Nov	Learn the five MAT question types	Two papers, untimed, just to see the patterns
Week 2, 4 to 10 Nov	Arithmetic's twelve topics, weakest three first	One full arithmetic section in 30 minutes
Week 3, 11 to 17 Nov	EVS recall and comprehension speed	Three full papers, timed
Week 4, 18 to 24 Nov	Exam simulation and OMR practice	Four full papers on OMR sheets

Week	Focus	Weekly target
Final days, 25 to 27 Nov	Light revision, sleep, logistics	No new material

Three things make the difference inside that plan.

First, practise on the actual answer format. The OMR sheet does not allow erasure, correction fluid or striking out, so a child who has only ever ticked answers in a workbook will lose marks to bubbling errors, not to ignorance. Print a plain grid of circles and have the child fill eighty of them in sequence while a timer runs.

Second, teach the sectional pass line explicitly. Your child should know that 14 out of 50 in Mental Ability and EVS, and 7 out of 25 in each of the other two, is the floor. That knowledge changes how a nine-year-old allocates time. A child stuck on one hard arithmetic question for six minutes is failing the strategy even if the answer is right.

Third, read aloud every day. The language section is four unseen passages in thirty minutes, which is a speed problem, not a vocabulary problem. Fifteen minutes of reading a Class V textbook chapter aloud, followed by five questions the parent asks, moves that score faster than any worksheet.

27. Exam morning: OMR discipline and the 1.25-mark arithmetic

The mechanics are published, and every one of them has cost somebody a seat.

- Carry the admit card. No candidate is allowed to appear without it. Be seated by 11:00 am; latecomers are not permitted.
- Carry two blue or black ball pens. Pencil is strictly prohibited on the OMR sheet.
- Check that the booklet number matches the OMR sheet number before you start, and check that the booklet is in the language you chose. Change of medium after the exam is not possible.
- Darken one circle per question properly. Striking out, white fluid and erasing are not allowed and such answers are not evaluated.
- Attempt every question. There is no negative marking, so an unmarked bubble is simply a wasted 1.25 marks.
- Watch the section clock. A bell rings every thirty minutes. The suggested split is 60 minutes for Mental Ability and EVS, 30 for Arithmetic and 30 for Language, though candidates may redistribute the two hours.
- Do not leave early. No candidate is permitted to leave the hall before the full time is over.

Divyang candidates get an additional 40 minutes. If your child qualifies, ask for it at the centre and confirm it on the admit card, rather than assuming it will be offered.

PART 7

Sainik School

An entrance test in January, a medical in April, and a cadet's life after that.

28. What a Sainik School is, and what it is not

Sainik Schools Society is an autonomous organisation under the Ministry of Defence. It runs English-medium residential schools affiliated to the CBSE, and their stated purpose is to prepare cadets for the National Defence Academy at Khadakwasla, the Indian Naval Academy at Ezhimala and other officer training academies. There are 33 Sainik Schools across the country.

Alongside them sits a newer category: approved New Sainik Schools, set up by the Ministry of Defence in partnership with NGOs, private schools and state governments. For the 2026-27 academic year there were 69 of them admitting at Class VI, and 19 that had progressed to Class IX. They teach their own affiliated board curriculum plus the Sainik School pattern academic-plus curriculum.

Three differences matter to a parent choosing between the two. Fees differ from school to school at a New Sainik School, because the fee structure is not uniform. The education board and the language of instruction also differ. And admission to a New Sainik School confers no right whatsoever to claim admission or transfer into one of the 33 Sainik Schools. If your plan is the NDA pipeline, know which of the two you are applying to.

29. AISSEE 2027: what is confirmed today, and what is not

This is the section where most online guides mislead parents, so here is the position checked on 28 October 2026.

Item	Status	Source
Exam date for AISSEE 2027	31 January 2027	NTA's examination calendar of 16 September 2026
Notification and information bulletin	Not yet released	NTA's AISSEE portal carried only 2026 notices on 28 October 2026
Application window	Expected October to November 2026, on the 2026 pattern	10 to 30 October 2025 in the 2026 cycle
Fee	Not announced for 2027. Was Rs. 850 for general, defence and OBC-NCL, and Rs. 700 for SC and ST in 2026	AISSEE 2026 information bulletin

Widely shared posts claiming that the AISSEE 2027 notification was released on 13 October 2026, complete with a fee table and application steps, are not supported by the official portal. On 28 October 2026 the NTA's AISSEE section listed eight public notices, every one of them for AISSEE 2026, the most recent being the result declaration. The News and Events tab read no post to display.

The thirty-second check that beats every forward

Open exams.nta.nic.in/sainik-school-society directly, not through a link someone sent you. Look at Public Notices. If you do not see a notice titled something like Inviting Online Applications for AISSEE 2027, the form is not out, whatever a reel, a WhatsApp group or a coaching centre says. Then read the information bulletin the day it appears, because the bulletin is the only document that binds NTA.

30. The Class VI paper: 125 questions, 300 marks

The 2026 scheme of examination is the best guide to what 2027 will look like, and it is unusually generous in one respect: there is no negative marking.

Sec	Subject	Questions	Marks each	Total
A	Language	25	2	50
B	Mathematics	50	3	150
C	Intelligence	25	2	50
D	General Knowledge	25	2	50
-	Total	125	-	300

Mathematics carries half the paper on its own, at 3 marks a question. That is the single most useful fact in this section: 50 mathematics questions are worth more than the other 75 questions combined. A candidate who is strong in arithmetic and weak everywhere else can still qualify comfortably. A candidate who is weak in mathematics cannot, however good the rest.

The paper runs 150 minutes, from 2:00 pm to 4:30 pm, in pen-and-paper OMR format. Class IX runs 180 minutes, from 2:00 to 5:00 pm, on a 400-mark scheme: Mathematics 50 questions at 4 marks each, and Intelligence, English, General Science and Social Science at 25 questions each at 2 marks.

Medium matters. For Class VI the paper is offered in English, Hindi, Assamese, Bengali, Gujarati, Kannada, Malayalam, Marathi, Odiya, Punjabi, Tamil, Telugu and Urdu, and the choice can be made irrespective of the school applied for. Candidates opting for English or Hindi receive a bilingual booklet. For Class IX the medium is English only. The medium once chosen cannot be changed, so choose it for the child's strength, not for the school's preference.

31. Applying without losing your candidature

The application itself is short, and the rules around it are unforgiving in three specific ways.

First, one application per level. If a candidate submits more than one application for admission at the same level, either Class VI or Class IX, all of them are summarily rejected. There is no appeal and no refund.

Second, the documents are uploaded at the application stage, not later, and the file specifications are fixed.

- Photograph, 10 to 200 kb, JPG.
- Candidate's signature, 10 to 50 kb, JPG.
- Candidate's left-hand thumb impression, 10 to 50 kb, JPG. If the left thumb is unavailable, the right may be used.
- Date of birth certificate issued by a competent authority, 50 to 300 kb, PDF.
- Domicile certificate, 50 to 300 kb, PDF.
- Caste, community or category certificate, where applicable.
- Certificate of service for serving defence category, and PPO for ex-servicemen, where applicable.
- Certificate from the Principal for candidates already studying in an approved New Sainik School.

Third, the fee must actually be paid. A form with an unpaid or failed transaction is incomplete and stands rejected, with no correspondence entertained. In the 2026 cycle the application window ran from 10 to 30 October 2025 with the last date for a successful fee transaction on 31 October, which is a reminder not to leave the payment to the final evening when bank servers slow down.

Two smaller items that matter later. You will be asked to choose four exam cities in order of preference, and NTA does not accept responsibility for inconvenience caused by incorrect city codes. And the email address and mobile number you enter are the ones used for the admit card, the result and the entire counselling process, so use a parent's, not a child's.

32. After the paper: e-counselling, medicals and documents

AISSEE is not the admission. It produces a merit list, and admission then runs through three further gates that can each end the process.

- Merit list and e-counselling. All India Sainik Schools Admission Counselling is a centralised online process in which candidates are allotted schools by rank and preference.
- Medical fitness. A candidate must be certified medically fit by a competent medical authority. This is a real filter, particularly for vision and general physical standards, and it is worth knowing the standards before the exam rather than after.
- Document verification. Original certificates are checked against what was uploaded. Any mismatch at this stage means denial of admission.

Results are declared within six weeks of the examination. The practical advice is to treat the month after the paper as an active month: keep the originals in one folder, keep the login credentials safe, and watch the counselling schedule on the official portal daily rather than weekly, because allotment windows in counselling are short and a missed acceptance is a lost seat.

PART 8

Decide and Execute

Four routes on one table, three families worked through, and a plan from today.

33. Four routes compared on the things that actually matter

	Private open seats	RTE 25%	Kendriya Vidyalaya	Navodaya and Sainik
Cost	Full fee	Free to Class 8	Very low fee	Free at JNV, subsidised at Sainik
Selection	Points, then draw	Computerised draw	Priority, then lotteries	Entrance test, then merit
Who applies	Anyone	EWS, DG and CWSN families	Anyone, with priorities	Anyone in the right age and district
Residential	No	No	No	Yes
Effort to apply	Medium, six schools	Low, one form	Low, one form	High, months of preparation
Control over outcome	None after applying	None	None	Direct, by performance

The honest reading of that table is that these routes are not substitutes. The two on the left are lotteries you enter and forget. The two on the right are exams your child prepares for, where effort maps to outcome. A family that only enters lotteries has no lever. A family that only prepares for exams ignores free seats it was entitled to. Do both, in the same year, for the same child.

34. Three families, worked end to end

Case one: a district-town family, household income Rs. 2.4 lakh, child in Class V in a government school in a rural block. The child is registered for JNVST 2027. The four weeks to 28 November go on the plan in Section 26, with arithmetic as the priority because 25 marks sit there and the pass mark is only 7. In parallel, the family checks the child's birth date against the 1 May 2015 to 31 July 2017 window, and confirms the school's rural status in writing from the headmaster, because a mismatch between UDISE+ data and the application is the commonest reason a rural-quota claim collapses at admission. If the child qualifies, the documents listed in the prospectus - birth certificate, residence certificate of the same district, Aadhaar, headmaster's certificate, migration undertaking - are assembled in February, not in April.

Case two: a Delhi family, household income Rs. 18 lakh, child turning three in January 2027. The child is outside the EWS income ceiling, so the RTE quota is closed. Three things happen in December. The family reads the published criteria for six schools on the DoE portal and computes its points for each, using road distance. It applies to all six in the first week of December, since forms opened on 4 December in the last cycle. And it checks whether any nearby Kendriya Vidyalaya runs Balvatika 1, because that registration opens in March and is a second, independent lottery for a child of exactly this age. In January the family checks the uploaded points on 9 and 16 January, which is where a 20-point error gets caught.

Case three: a central government employee transferred to a new city in June 2026, child aged 7. Category 1 at a civil-sector KV, with two transfers in the last seven years on the service certificate. The registration window in March is the main event, and the service certificate - signed by the head of office, showing the number of transfers in the preceding seven years - is obtained in February, because a certificate that says only transferable post will not establish the category. In parallel the family applies to two private schools for Class II and files the offline KV form in the 2 to 8 April window if vacancies exist, because Category 1

applicants who missed the Class I cycle routinely get in through Class II vacancies.

35. Your ninety-day plan from today

Today is 28 October 2026. Here is what the next ninety days look like if you are running more than one route.

When	Do this	Why now
28 Oct to 5 Nov	Build the document folder from Section 5. Request the income and domicile certificates	These take weeks and gate everything else
28 Oct to 27 Nov	If registered for JNVST, run the four-week plan in Section 26	The test is on 28 November
6 to 20 Nov	Shortlist six Delhi schools and note their 2026-27 criteria as a guide	The 2027-28 criteria appear in late November
21 to 30 Nov	Read the Delhi DoE notification the day it is issued and recompute your points	Criteria change every year
1 to 15 Dec	Submit every private school application in the first week	Forms opened 4 December last cycle
1 to 15 Dec	Check whether a nearby KV runs Balvatika and note its March window	A second, independent lottery
15 Dec to 5 Jan	Confirm the child's PEN and APAAR status with the school	Fixes name mismatches before they cost a week
5 to 20 Jan	Verify your uploaded details and points on the school's page	The ten-day query window is the only remedy
January	If applying to AISSEE, read the bulletin the day it is published	The 2027 bulletin is not out yet
February	Get the income certificate reissued for the RTE window	The 2026-27 window opened 21 February

36. Twelve questions to ask the school before you pay

Ask these at the admission desk, in this order. The answers tell you more than any brochure.

- Is the school recognised, and what is the recognition number? An unrecognised school cannot issue a valid transfer certificate or board registration.
- What was the fee in each of the last three years, and what is it this year? A school that will not answer this in writing is telling you something.
- What is the total annual cost, including transport, activity, exam and annual charges, not just tuition?
- How many students per section, and how many teachers per section?
- Who teaches Class I, and what is their qualification?
- What is the transport route and the pick-up time for my address?
- Is there a nurse or a first-aid room, and what is the protocol for a medical emergency?
- What is the school's policy on physical punishment, and where is it written down?
- How are fee increases approved, and is there a parent committee?
- What is the refund policy if we withdraw within a month?
- Can I see the last three years' Class X or XII board results, not just the toppers?

- Will you give me the admission confirmation and fee receipt in writing, with the school seal?

37. The scams and the red flags

Every admission season produces the same small set of frauds. They are recognisable.

- The seat-confirmation donation. A demand for a donation, development fee or capitation payment as the condition for confirming a seat is a capitation fee under Section 2(b) of the RTE Act, and the penalty under Section 13(2) is up to ten times the amount charged. Pay nothing without a receipt that names the fee head.
- The agent who guarantees admission. Nobody can guarantee a computerised draw. An agent who claims an inside line to a lottery is either lying or buying you a seat that was never yours, which will be cancelled when the records are checked.
- The fake notification forward. A screenshot with a fee table and a closing date, forwarded through a parents' group, is the most common misinformation in this entire process. Every one of the four routes publishes its dates on a government domain. Check there.
- The expired certificate. An agent offering to arrange an income certificate quickly usually means a certificate that will not survive verification. Admission secured on a wrong certificate is cancelled forthwith, with no appeal.
- The early-payment pressure. A school demanding full-year fees before the list is published, or before you have a written confirmation, is creating a problem you will spend months undoing.
- The unrecognised school with a big board. Check recognition before you check anything else. An unrecognised school cannot deliver a valid board registration, and your child's records will be a problem for years.

> **One rule that covers all six**
>
> Nothing important in this process happens on a phone call. A date, a fee, a seat, a rejection - each of them becomes real only in a document: a portal notice, an SMS from the department, a signed letter, or a receipt with a seal. Ask for it in writing, every time, and keep it.

38. The one-page action card

Print this page and put it on the fridge.

If your child is	Do this first
Turning 3 before 31 March 2027	Delhi private school forms, first week of December. Then check KV Balvatika in March
Turning 4 or 5 before 31 March 2027	Delhi LKG or UKG forms in December. Note that 2027-28 is the first year these classes exist
Turning 6 before 31 March 2027	Class I: private open seats in December, KV in March, RTE in February if income is under the state ceiling
In Class V now, registered for JNVST	The four-week plan in Section 26. Test on 28 November 2026
In Class V now, not registered	AISSEE on 31 January 2027 if eligible. Otherwise JNVST 2028, register in July 2027
In Class V, family income below the state RTE ceiling	Apply for the RTE quota in February as well. It is free education to Class 8

If your child is	Do this first
Any age, moving city mid-year	KV offline vacancy route in April and July, and the school's own mid-year vacancy list
Any age, first application ever	Build the twelve-document folder before anything else

39. Sources, and how this was verified

Every rule, date and fee in this book comes from a government document or a government portal, read on or before 28 October 2026. Where a date belongs to the previous cycle and the current one has not been announced, the book says so rather than presenting a guess as a fact.

- Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education Act, 2009, as amended, including Sections 2(b), 2(o), 2(p), 12, 13, 14, 15, 16 and 17. Department of School Education and Literacy, Ministry of Education.
- Directorate of Education, GNCT of Delhi: circular dated 22 November 2025 on the admission schedule for entry-level classes for 2026-27, and circular dated 24 October 2025 on the uniform age of admission of 6+ in Class I and the restructuring of the foundational stage, both on edudel.nic.in.
- Directorate of Education, GNCT of Delhi: published admission criteria of recognised private unaided schools for 2026-27, district-wise report on edudel.nic.in, used for the school criteria table in Section 8.
- Directorate of Education, GNCT of Delhi: EWS, DG and Freeship admission portal at ewsadmissions.delhi.gov.in, including the published FAQs and the 2026-27 circulars.
- Kendriya Vidyalaya Sangathan: Admission Guidelines 2026-27 and onwards, and Admission Notice 2026-27, on kvsangathan.nic.in.
- Navodaya Vidyalaya Samiti: Prospectus cum Notification for JNVST 2027, Class VI admission for session 2027-28, on navodaya.gov.in.
- National Testing Agency and Sainik Schools Society: AISSEE 2026 Information Bulletin, and the AISSEE portal at exams.nta.nic.in/sainik-school-society, checked on 28 October 2026.
- Ministry of Education: APAAR portal at apaar.education.gov.in, including the consent and PEN prerequisites and the helpline.

A note on what will change

Four documents will be issued between now and April 2027 that supersede parts of this book: the Delhi DoE entry-level circular for 2027-28, the AISSEE 2027 information bulletin, the KVS admission notice for 2027-28, and the state RTE notifications. Read each one when it appears. This book tells you what to look for, which is the part that saves time; the notification is always the final word.

Appendix A. A forty-question practice set for the JNVST

Twenty arithmetic questions and twenty mental ability and EVS questions, written to the JNVST 2027 syllabus and at the Class V level the paper assumes. Answers and one-line explanations follow. Time the arithmetic set at 30 minutes and the second set at 60 minutes, and mark on an OMR-style grid rather than in the margin.

Arithmetic, 20 questions in 30 minutes.

- 1. What is the smallest four-digit number you can make using 3, 0, 7 and 5, each exactly once?
- 2. In the number 4,68,207, what is the place value of the digit 6?

- 3. Add 7,845 and 2,968.
- 4. Subtract 2,745 from 6,000.
- 5. Multiply 248 by 36.
- 6. Divide 4,536 by 24.
- 7. How many factors does 36 have?
- 8. Find the LCM of 6 and 8, and the HCF of 24 and 36.
- 9. Add three-fourths and one-eighth.
- 10. Multiply two-thirds by 9.
- 11. A road is 1 km 250 m long. Another 750 m is added. What is the total length in kilometres?
- 12. A bag weighs 3 kg 500 g. Rice weighing 1 kg 750 g is removed. What remains?
- 13. A film starts at 4:45 pm and runs for 2 hours 40 minutes. When does it end?
- 14. A child has five notes of Rs. 200 and three coins of Rs. 5. How much money is that?
- 15. Simplify: 12 + 6 x 3 - 4.
- 16. What is the perimeter of a rectangle 12 cm long and 8 cm wide?
- 17. What is the area of a square of side 9 cm?
- 18. A rectangle is 10 cm by 6 cm. A triangle is drawn on its base using the full height. What is the triangle's area?
- 19. The minute hand of a clock points at 12 and the hour hand at 3. What is the angle between them?
- 20. In a pictograph one symbol stands for 5 students. Seven symbols are drawn. How many students is that?

Mental ability and EVS, 20 questions in 60 minutes.

- 21. Complete the series: 2, 6, 12, 20, 30, ?
- 22. Complete the series: 1, 4, 9, 16, 25, ?
- 23. Complete the letter series: A, C, F, J, ?
- 24. Complete the series: 3, 6, 12, 24, ?
- 25. Which is the odd one out: 4, 9, 16, 25, 30?
- 26. Which is the largest state of India by area?
- 27. What is the national animal of India?
- 28. Which gas do plants take in during photosynthesis?
- 29. Which is the longest river in India?
- 30. How many states and how many union territories does India have?
- 31. Which vitamin does the body make from sunlight?
- 32. Which instrument is used to measure temperature?
- 33. What is the national bird of India?
- 34. In the water cycle, what is the process by which water vapour becomes water droplets called?

- 35. Which harvest festival is celebrated in Punjab?
- 36. Which of these is a renewable resource: coal, petrol, wind, diesel?
- 37. What is the capital of India?
- 38. How many bones does an adult human body have?
- 39. Which part of a plant makes food?
- 40. If you face north and turn 90 degrees clockwise, which direction are you facing?

Appendix A. Answers, with the reasoning

Q	Answer	Why
1	3057	Zero cannot lead a four-digit number, so it takes the second place
2	60,000	The 6 sits in the ten-thousands place
3	10,813	Straight addition
4	3,255	Borrowing from the thousands
5	8,928	248 x 36, worked in two steps
6	189	24 x 189 = 4,536
7	9 factors	1, 2, 3, 4, 6, 9, 12, 18, 36
8	LCM 24, HCF 12	Multiples of 8 meet multiples of 6 first at 24
9	7/8	Three-fourths is six-eighths, plus one-eighth
10	6	Nine divided into thirds is three, times two
11	2 km	250 m plus 750 m is a full kilometre
12	1 kg 750 g	3,500 g minus 1,750 g
13	7:25 pm	4:45 plus 2 hours is 6:45, plus 40 minutes is 7:25
14	Rs. 1,015	1,000 plus 15
15	26	Multiplication first: 12 plus 18 minus 4
16	40 cm	Twice the sum of length and width
17	81 sq cm	9 x 9
18	30 sq cm	A triangle on the same base and height is half the rectangle
19	90 degrees	Three hours of five-minute spaces, at 30 degrees each
20	35 students	Seven symbols times five
21	42	Differences rise by two each time: 4, 6, 8, 10, 12
22	36	The squares of 1 to 6
23	O	The gaps are 2, 3, 4, so the next gap is 5: J plus 5 is O
24	48	Each term doubles
25	30	The others are perfect squares
26	Rajasthan	By area
27	Tiger	National animal
28	Carbon dioxide	Taken in through the leaves

Q	Answer	Why
29	Ganga	Longest river within India
30	28 states, 8 union territories	Current position
31	Vitamin D	Synthesised in skin exposed to sunlight
32	Thermometer	Standard instrument
33	Peacock	National bird
34	Condensation	Vapour to droplets; the reverse is evaporation
35	Baisakhi	Harvest festival of Punjab
36	Wind	The only one that is replenished
37	New Delhi	Capital
38	206	Adult count; a newborn has more, which fuse over time
39	The leaf	Where photosynthesis happens
40	East	Clockwise from north is east

How to use the score

Below 10 out of 20 in arithmetic means the 7-mark pass line is at risk and arithmetic should take the whole of the next week. Between 10 and 14 means the pass line is safe and the work is speed. Above 14 means arithmetic is an asset and the marks to chase are in comprehension, which is the section most children lose to the clock rather than to difficulty.

Appendix B. Mid-year and transfer admissions

Every part of this book assumes the normal cycle. Families move in June, in October, and in the middle of a term, and the rules for that are different and much less written about.

The law is on your side here. Section 5 of the RTE Act gives a child the right to seek transfer to another school during the academic year where the family has moved, and requires the school to issue the transfer certificate. Practically, that means a school cannot hold a transfer certificate hostage to unpaid fees in a way that blocks the child's education, and it cannot refuse to issue one because the year has already begun.

What you actually need in hand when you walk into a new school mid-year:

- The transfer certificate from the previous school, showing name, date of birth, class last attended, subjects studied, whether the child was promoted, the date of leaving and the board registration number where applicable. In some states this is called the school leaving certificate, and the two are the same document.
- The last report card or mark sheet.
- The birth certificate and Aadhaar, with the PEN and APAAR ID noted alongside them.
- A migration certificate if the child is changing boards - typically relevant from Class IX onwards when moving between a state board and the CBSE.
- A bonafide certificate from the previous school if you are applying while the child is still enrolled there.

Two official points that make mid-year admission easier than parents expect. Delhi's 24 October 2025 circular states that regular students who have passed the previous class from a recognised school and hold a valid school leaving certificate and mark sheet are exempt from the age-appropriateness criteria for

admission to the next higher class. In plain terms, a child moving up a class is not re-tested against the age band. And Kendriya Vidyalaya's guidelines allow admission up to Class VIII without any transfer certificate at all, provided the child is otherwise eligible and the birth certificate was issued by a government body.

What no rule can give you is a vacancy. Mid-year seats appear in three places, and all three reward the parent who asks repeatedly rather than the one who asks once. Private schools publish vacancies on their own websites and rarely advertise them. Kendriya Vidyalayas publicise vacancies locally and on the Vidyalaya website, and the guidelines allow registration once a vacancy arises after wide publicity at local level. Navodaya does not admit mid-year at all outside its own selection test, so plan around that.

The one habit that wins mid-year seats

Ask in writing, in the first week of April, the first week of July and the first week of October, and ask the same question every time: do you have a vacancy in Class X, and may I submit an application today. Keep the replies. Schools fill mid-year vacancies from the folder of parents who are already in touch, not from the queue that turns up on the day.

Appendix C. The words on the forms, decoded

Every form in this book uses the same short list of terms. Here is what each one actually means, so you are not guessing at a counter.

Term	What it means
APAAR	Automated Permanent Academic Account Registry, the 12-digit One Nation One Student ID, generated through the school against the child's PEN
AISSAC	All India Sainik Schools Admission Counselling, the centralised e-counselling that follows the AISSEE result
AISSEE	All India Sainik Schools Entrance Examination, conducted by NTA for Class VI and Class IX admission
Balvatika	The NEP 2020 three-year pre-primary stage: Balvatika 1, 2 and 3, formerly nursery, lower KG and upper KG
Bonafide certificate	A school's written confirmation that a named child is a current student there
CWSN	Children with Special Needs, used for the 3% horizontal reservation and for the Delhi quota
DG	Disadvantaged Group, covering SC, ST, OBC non-creamy layer, orphans, transgender children and children affected by HIV
Draw of lots	A random selection used when applicants tie on points or exceed seats. In Delhi it must be held before parents and video-recorded
DDE	Deputy Director of Education, the district-level officer who chairs Delhi's Monitoring Cell
EWS	Economically Weaker Section, defined by an income ceiling set by the state
JNVST	Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya Selection Test, the Class VI entrance test for Navodaya schools
Management quota	A block of seats a private school fills at its own discretion, typically 20% at entry level in Delhi
NCL	Non-Creamy Layer, the income test inside the OBC category
Open seats	The seats a private school fills through its published points system, after reservations and management quota
PEN	Permanent Education Number, the child's identifier in UDISE+
Points system	The published criteria and weightings a private school uses to rank applicants, which must be displayed publicly

Term	What it means
RTE	Right to Education, meaning the Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education Act, 2009
Screening procedure	Any selection method other than a random one, prohibited at admission under Section 13 of the RTE Act
SLC	School Leaving Certificate, the same document as a transfer certificate in several states
TC	Transfer Certificate, issued by the school a child is leaving
UDISE+	The national school and student database that issues the PEN and generates the APAAR ID
UDID	Unique Disability ID, the card that carries a certified benchmark disability
VVN	Vidyalaya Vikas Nidhi, the monthly charge at Navodaya schools from Classes IX to XII